congratulations on his arrival in the city, promoting him to the rank of lieutenant, and he was ushered straight into the office of Count Nesselrode, the Russian Vice Chancellor and Foreign Minister.

News of Mirza Hussein Ali's mission had been greeted with enormous excitement by all the officials concerned with the incipient Great Game. Count Simonitch had written from the Teheran Legation urging that this opportunity should not be lost. British influence in Persia was already on the wane, he wrote. Now the chance had come to include Afghanistan in a tripartite alliance of Russia, Persia and 'Kabulistan'. In this way, an arc of Russian influence could be established from Kabul to Tabriz. With the Russians supreme in Afghanistan, the British would be on the back foot, struggling to maintain their position on the Indus, and would have no chance of creating more trouble in Russia's natural zone of influence in Central Asia. Moreover, Russian political influence in Kabul would open up the markets of Afghanistan to Russian produce.[25]

The Governor of Orenburg agreed. It was, he wrote,

> absolutely necessary to support the Kabul leader [Dost Mohammad Khan]. For if the British puppet Shuja becomes ruler of Afghanistan then the country will come under British influence, and the British will only have to take one step to be in Bukhara. Central Asia will then be altogether under British influence, our trade with Asia will cease, and the British will be able to arm the neighbouring Asian countries as well as provide them with power, arms and money against Russia. If the patronage of Russia can support Dost Mohammad on the throne, he will undoubtedly, in gratitude, remain a good friend of ours and an enemy to the English; he will cut them off from Central Asia, will place a barrier to their beloved trading power.[26]

The Governor also urged that Vitkevitch should be given the job of escorting the Afghan Ambassador back home as he was 'an efficient, clever man who knows his job, is of a practical nature, more prone to act than to write or talk, and knows the steppe and its inhabitants better than any person living or dead'.[27]

On arrival in St Petersburg, the letter from Dost Mohammad was closely examined and proved to be all that was hoped. Dost Mohammad wrote that the British were on the verge of conquering all of India, and that he alone was capable of stopping their advance, if only he were to be supplied with arms and money in the way that the Russians were doing with the Persians: 'We hope that the magnanimity and unparalleled bounties showered on the Persian court will also stream on the Afghan government and on our